

UX CASE STUDY

Zomato — Food Delivery App

Analysis of User Journey, Strengths, Weaknesses,
and Three Proposed Improvements

UI/UX Design Internship — CodeAlpha

Task 3: UX Case Study Report

1. Introduction

Zomato is one of the most widely used food delivery and restaurant discovery applications, serving a very large monthly user base. The app allows users to discover restaurants, browse menus, read reviews, place food orders, and track delivery in real time. Because food ordering is a high-frequency, often impulsive activity, the user experience must be fast, clear, and reassuring.

This case study examines Zomato from a UI/UX perspective. It maps the typical user journey, evaluates the app's key strengths and weaknesses, and proposes three concrete improvements. The goal is to demonstrate structured UX thinking: observing real user behaviour, identifying friction points, and proposing solutions grounded in usability principles rather than personal preference.

Scope note: This analysis is based on publicly observable app behaviour, published UX research, and standard usability heuristics. It is an academic learning exercise and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Zomato.

2. User Journey Analysis

The journey below describes the path of a typical user — a hungry person who wants to order a meal quickly. Each stage is mapped to what the user does, what they feel, and where friction can occur.

Stage 1 — Open & Locate

The user opens the app and the home screen loads with their saved delivery location at the top. They are immediately shown nearby restaurants, offers, and food categories. Emotion: hungry, slightly impatient, scanning quickly for something appealing.

Stage 2 — Discover & Search

The user either browses curated sections (“Recommended”, cuisines, offers) or uses the search bar to look for a specific dish or restaurant. Filters such as rating, delivery time, price, and pure-veg help narrow the choice. Emotion: exploring, comparing options, wanting to decide fast without being overwhelmed.

Stage 3 — Evaluate Restaurant & Menu

After tapping a restaurant, the user reviews the menu, photos, ratings, delivery time, and any offers. They add items to the cart. Emotion: evaluating value for money, checking if the minimum order and delivery fee feel reasonable.

Stage 4 — Cart & Checkout

The user reviews the cart, applies a coupon, selects the delivery address, and chooses a payment method. The final bill, including taxes and delivery charges, is shown before confirming. Emotion: a moment of price sensitivity — unexpected charges here cause hesitation or cart abandonment.

Stage 5 — Order Tracking

Once the order is placed, the user tracks its progress: order confirmed, food being prepared, rider assigned, out for delivery, and a live map of the rider. Emotion: anticipation; the user wants reassurance and an accurate time estimate.

Stage 6 — Delivery & Post-Order

The food arrives and the user is prompted to rate the restaurant and the delivery experience. This feedback feeds back into ratings for future users. Emotion: satisfaction if expectations were met; frustration if the food or timing disappointed.

3. Strengths of the Current Design

Zomato performs strongly in several areas of user experience:

- **Strong personalization:** The home screen arranges restaurants and dishes based on order history, cuisine preference, and time of day. A prominent “Recommended” section reduces choice overload and helps hungry users decide faster.
- **Clear visual hierarchy after redesign:** Recent redesigns have focused on cutting visual clutter, giving food imagery and key information more breathing room and making the home screen easier to scan.
- **Rich, trustworthy content:** High-quality food photos, detailed menus, ratings, and user reviews give users confidence before ordering. Peer signals such as friend recommendations increase trust.
- **Real-time order tracking:** Live status updates and a map of the rider reduce post-order anxiety, one of the most emotionally sensitive stages of the journey.
- **Consistent, recognizable branding:** A playful, distinctive visual identity and familiar navigation patterns make the app feel reliable and easy to return to.
- **Effective use of behavioural design:** Default sections and curated combinations gently guide users toward quick decisions, aligning user convenience with business goals.

4. Weaknesses & Pain Points

Despite its strengths, several friction points can weaken the experience:

- **Information density on the home screen:** Even after redesigns, the home screen can feel busy — banners, offers, multiple carousels, and categories compete for attention and can overwhelm a user who just wants to order quickly.
- **Pricing surprises at checkout:** Delivery fees, taxes, platform fees, and surge charges often become fully visible only near the final step. This late reveal causes hesitation and cart abandonment.
- **Limited search within a restaurant:** Once inside a restaurant, finding a specific dish in a long menu can be slow, as filtering and in-menu search are not always prominent.
- **Notification and offer overload:** Frequent promotional notifications and offer banners can feel intrusive and create noise around genuinely useful order updates.
- **Cognitive load for first-time users:** New users face many sections and choices at once, without enough progressive guidance to ease them into the core ordering flow.

5. Proposed Improvements

The following three improvements target the most impactful pain points identified above. Each includes the problem, the proposed solution, a description of the mockup concept, and the expected benefit.

Improvement 1 — Transparent Pricing Summary

1. **Problem:** Users discover the full cost (delivery fee, taxes, platform fee) only at the final checkout step, causing hesitation and abandoned carts.
2. **Solution:** Introduce an always-visible mini price summary on the restaurant and cart screens. As items are added, a small bar at the bottom shows the running item total and an estimated “all-in” price including fees, so there are no surprises later.
3. **Mockup concept:** A sticky bottom bar reading “Items ₹320 · Est. total ₹389 (incl. fees) ›”. Tapping it expands a clear breakdown of every charge.
4. **Expected benefit:** Builds trust through transparency, reduces checkout drop-off, and removes the negative emotional spike of unexpected charges.

Improvement 2 — Simplified, Focused Home Screen

5. **Problem:** The home screen presents many competing banners, carousels, and categories at once, increasing cognitive load for users who simply want to order food fast.
6. **Solution:** Add a streamlined “Quick Order” mode at the top of the home screen — a compact area showing “Reorder your last meal” and three personalized one-tap suggestions. Promotional banners move below this focused zone.
7. **Mockup concept:** The top third of the home screen shows a clean card: “Order again — [last restaurant]” plus three suggested dishes as simple tappable cards. Offers and carousels appear only after the user scrolls.
8. **Expected benefit:** Speeds up the most common task (reordering), reduces visual clutter, and respects the hungry user's need for a fast decision.

Improvement 3 — Smart In-Restaurant Dish Search

9. **Problem:** Finding a specific item inside a long restaurant menu is slow, as in-menu search and filtering are not prominent.
10. **Solution:** Add a clearly visible search bar pinned at the top of every restaurant menu, with quick filter chips such as “Bestsellers”, “Veg”, “Under ₹200”, and “Spicy”.
11. **Mockup concept:** A pinned search field reading “Search this menu...” sits directly below the restaurant header, with a horizontal row of filter chips beneath it. Selecting a chip instantly filters the menu list.
12. **Expected benefit:** Cuts the time to find a desired dish, reduces frustration with long menus, and improves the evaluation stage of the journey.

Summary of Improvements

Pain Point	Proposed Solution	Expected Benefit
Hidden costs at checkout	Always-visible all-in price summary	More trust, less cart abandonment
Cluttered home screen	Focused Quick Order zone	Faster reordering, lower cognitive load
Hard to find dishes in menu	Pinned in-menu search + filter chips	Quicker discovery, less frustration

6. Conclusion

Zomato is a mature, well-designed product with strong personalization, rich content, and reassuring order tracking. Its main weaknesses are not broken features but friction points: a dense home screen, late pricing transparency, and slow in-menu discovery.

The three improvements proposed here — a transparent pricing summary, a focused home screen, and smart in-restaurant search — each target a specific stage of the user journey where users feel hesitation or frustration. They follow core UX principles: reduce cognitive load, build trust through transparency, and speed up the user's primary task. Together they would make an already strong app feel faster, calmer, and more trustworthy.

Key takeaway: Good UX improvement is not about adding more features. It is about removing friction from the path the user already wants to take.